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MKTG 198R

30 September 2025

Assignment 3: Reflection and Lessons

This summer I had the opportunity to take part in Nordstrom's Retail Leadership Training Program. The program lasted nine weeks with a forty hour work week. Throughout the program interns learn the ins and outs of becoming an Assistant Department Manager at Nordstrom at an accelerated pace. Each intern is placed in a department, and I was placed in the Men's Furnishing's Department. This was an interesting and competitive department to be a part of because the four top sellers at the store work in this department. At the end of the program interns will receive an offer to work as an ADM at the Nordstrom they are currently employed at or one nearby. During weeks two and three, the other interns and I spent two weeks working at the Nordstrom Rack in East Palo Alto. While we were there we spent time with different departments such as women's clothing, handbags and accessories, shoes, inventory and operations. While we were shadowing inventory and operations we did RFID counts, tagging, and product processing. Something that I found interesting at the Rack is that when product gets delivered from the truck each morning it is important to get as much product processed as possible, so it can get out on the floor quickly, which differs from full line. Nordstrom (full line) has a curated and methodical way of placing merchandise on the floor in order to draw consumers in.

After spending two weeks at Nordstrom Rack, we went straight into working during Nordstrom's Anniversary Sale. The Anniversary Sale was our main focus for two weeks, as it is

the busiest time for Nordstrom. During this time we focused on sales and getting customers to join the Nordy Club rewards program. In hopes that we get more customers to come back to get early access with their Nordstrom Credit Card for the next Anniversary sale. Once foot traffic died down from the sale we were able to shadow departments such as Operations, Online, and Customer Service each bringing new insights and skills. One of my favorite departments that we shadowed was Customer Service. It is a really fast paced environment that requires a lot of patience and quick problem solving, which makes it fun and engaging. We got to listen to the customers and learn about their shopping experience and history and are given the chance to help and listen to them. I enjoyed learning from the Service Experience Manager as he dealt with difficult situations. We were able to see how important it is to navigate each customer with patience and understanding as he navigated the issue at hand.

Towards the end of the program, the other interns and I made a presentation on ways Nordstrom could increase sales through the Nordy Club, which we then presented to our store manager and department managers. This presentation focused on how the Nordy Club credit card can boost customer loyalty and sales at Nordstrom. It shows that cardholders tend to spend much more, making it valuable for both the customer and the store. The main goal was to encourage store teams to get more customers to open cards, which would increase participation in the rewards program. We shared current performance numbers, pointed out where departments are falling short, and highlighted how good communication with customers, such as small talk, being helpful, and following up always makes a difference. To help teams succeed, we suggested three strategies: getting to know and motivate employees, running a fun “Credit Card Classroom” training with role-play and discussions, and offering simple incentives like gift cards, coffee, or

preferred shifts. With these different strategies we are hoping to provide managers new ways to motivate their teams.

Before this internship I did not have any prior experience working retail, so it is safe to say that I learned a lot while being a part of this program. Some of the lessons that stand out to me are how important product placement and knowledge, knowing the customer, growing your network, and leading a team. Firstly, merchandising is very important as it influences the customer's decision. I noticed that every manager has different ways to present their merchandise, for example, my manager based her floor plan off of the brands that were selling and pushed those to the front of the floor. Another takeaway is asking the right questions when speaking with customers, and bringing a relevant selection to them. Taking the time to get all the right information is crucial because if done incorrectly the customer can get frustrated quickly and then you lose the sale. Here is an example: I was helping a customer who was looking for a suit, doing the best I could, I pulled some suits that I thought would work for him. The suits I pulled were not fitting right and the customer was starting to get frustrated. I asked my coworker and we were able to find the right size and fit. Looking back I think I should have asked more questions of the customer (who did not know their size) such as what brands have you worn in the past? What are the sizes of your other suits (if applicable)? Asking questions like these would have given me more to work with in order to find the right fit. Another key takeaway was the value of growing your professional network within Nordstrom. Connecting with managers, peers, and mentors gave me broader insight into the business and reinforced how collaboration drives success. Finally, I developed skills in leading a team, from motivating sales associates to setting goals and ensuring we provided an excellent customer experience. These lessons,

combined, gave me a strong foundation in retail management and showed me how leadership, strategy, and customer service intersect on the sales floor.

Nordstrom is known for being customer centric, and always putting their customers first. This became more and more apparent to me in the Men's Department. Every morning the morning manager in charge would announce the top department that made their goal the day before, along with the top sellers of the entire store. There were four top sellers in my department, and they always had customers returning to be helped by those sales associates specifically. Seeing customers return to specific associates because of the relationships they had built really highlighted the human side of retail for me and why people keep shopping at Nordstrom.

This internship gave me tangible skills and experiences that I can now speak to in interviews. I learned how to communicate with customers effectively, tailoring my approach to different personalities and needs, which directly demonstrates customer-facing and interpersonal skills. I also developed leadership abilities ranging from motivating team members on the sales floor to helping drive toward department goals, which show I can take on responsibility and manage others. Additionally, I became much more comfortable with problem-solving in fast-paced environments, whether that meant handling customer concerns on the spot or adjusting product placement to improve sales flow. Altogether, these experiences give me concrete examples to share in an interview about how I contribute to teamwork, leadership, and customer success.

The EMPAC model was super helpful to me during the interview process and while working, since I did my analysis on Nordstrom. I learned how much Nordstrom emphasizes making shopping an engaging experience, whether through curated displays, personalized

styling, or even just the energy on the sales floor. It is not just about selling clothes, it is about creating an environment where customers enjoy spending their time. Additionally, I learned how essential convenience is to the modern shopping experience. Services like BOPUS (Buy Online, Pick Up in Store), easy returns, and mobile checkout were huge differentiators. Watching how seamless processes influenced customer satisfaction helped me understand why convenience is such a critical driver of loyalty. Overall, EMPAC gave me a framework for understanding why Nordstrom's customer experience feels so unique. It helped me analyze Nordstrom's product and services and moving forward I think completing the EMPAC model for companies that I am interviewing for would be very beneficial for preparation.